Suffolk lawmakers press Flock Safety on privacy, surveillance concerns

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Suffolk County lawmakers challenged representatives from Flock Safety during a tense Public Safety Committee hearing Thursday, raising questions about privacy, data collection and the potential for misuse of the company's license plate reader technology.

Flock Safety manufactures artificial intelligence-powered license plate readers that are used by the Suffolk County Police Department, the sheriff's office and several East End law enforcement agencies. Supporters of the technology say it helps investigators solve crimes, recover stolen vehicles and locate missing persons. Critics, however, argue the devices contribute to mass surveillance and raise significant privacy concerns.

A sharp exchange came when Suffolk County Legislative Presiding Officer Anthony Piccirillo pressed company officials about the scope of Flock's camera network.

"Isn't it true you've constructed a nationwide surveillance network capable of reconstructing an individual's movements over time?" Piccirillo asked.

Flock Safety senior director of Public Affairs Trevor Chandler pushed back on that characterization, arguing the technology has repeatedly withstood legal scrutiny.

"This is a law enforcement tool," Chandler said. "The legal definitions are significant. The courts have found it's not a surveillance tool that can track a person's course of daily life."

Much of the hearing focused on how information collected by the cameras is stored, who can access it and what safeguards exist to prevent abuse.

Flock representatives told lawmakers that agencies, not the company, control the data generated by the cameras. They also said every search conducted within the system is logged and can be audited to detect improper use.

The discussion comes after a recent News 12 special report identified dozens of incidents around the country in which law enforcement officials allegedly used Flock's system to monitor or search for romantic interests, raising concerns about potential abuse of the technology.

Suffolk Chief Assistant District Attorney Alan Bodie said county officials take such allegations seriously and warned that misuse would carry consequences.

"If someone here were to do like has been reported in other places in the country and run their boyfriend or girlfriend a thousand times, they're going to go to jail," Bodie said.

Despite assurances from both the company and local law enforcement officials, some legislators suggested additional policies may be needed to ensure the technology is not used improperly.

Legislator Trish Bergin said lawmakers should play a role in developing safeguards that protect residents' privacy.

"Perhaps we can be part of the discussions to make sure this is not an overreach on the part of you, law enforcement or bad actors," Bergin said.

The hearing reflects an ongoing debate over the growing use of automated license plate readers, which have become an increasingly common investigative tool for police agencies across Long Island and throughout the country.

Meanwhile, Suffolk County officials recently paused plans to move forward with a proposed $4 million agreement with Flock Safety for gunshot detection technology.

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